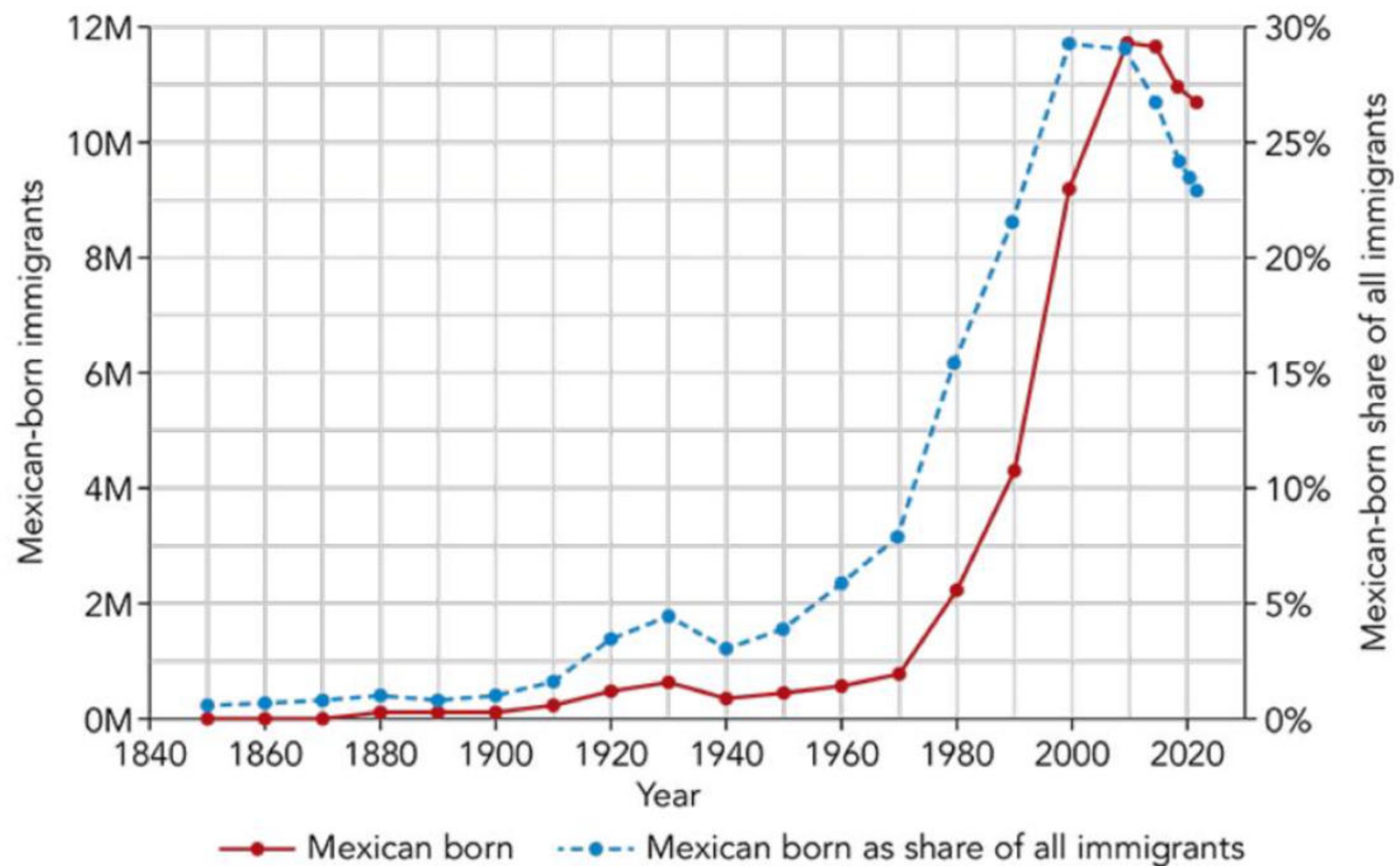


6.5 Detailed specific example: International migration from Mexico to the USA



Mexico and the USA is a rare example where a **Middle-income country (MIC)** borders a HIC. In 2024, approximately 11 million Mexicans live in the USA. Many live in the USA legally with 'Green Card' status, which gives the right to permanently live in the USA and gain citizenship. In 2020, nearly 100 000 Mexicans received legal 'Green Card' status. However, illegal migration is a big problem, with 5 million illegal Mexican immigrants entering the USA in 2020.



Source A: The number of Mexican immigrants and their share of the total US immigrant population over time.

TASK 1: Study Source A

Source A shows the number of Mexican immigrants and their share of the total US immigrant population over time.

- Describe the changes** in the number of Mexican-born immigrants living in the USA since 1970.
- Suggest reasons for the sharp decline in the rate of Mexico to US immigration since 2010.

Push and pull factors

The US-Mexico border is the world's largest bilateral migrant (movement of people between two countries) corridor. There are a number of mainly social, economic, and political reasons why many Mexicans want to leave Mexico to live in the USA.

Table 6.6: Push and pull factors of migration from Mexico to the USA

Push factors	Pull factors
In the last decade, some parts of Mexico have become more dangerous as a result of political instability, with drug war violence that has led to disappearances, deaths, and kidnappings.	The USA is more politically stable and there are fewer human rights violations.
Corruption has caused unstable employment and lack of opportunity.	There are employment opportunities in key industries such as agriculture, construction, and hospitality.
Proximity (Mexico and the USA have a 3139 km land border).	There are strong cultural ties to Mexico within the existing US population and society (many US citizens are second/third/fourth generation immigrants).
Poor medical facilities: there are 1800 people per doctor and poor education prospects (adult literacy rate is 55%).	Good medical facilities: there are 400 people per doctor and excellent education prospects (adult literacy rates is 99%)
In rural areas of Mexico, poverty is a problem for farmers working on small farms.	Wages in jobs such as agriculture, construction, and hospitality are potentially much higher in the USA.
GNI per capita is \$10 820 (2022).	GNI per capita is \$76 370 (2022).

Impacts of migration

Mexicans migrating to the USA cause a range of social and economic impacts on both Mexico and the USA. For Mexico, it is mainly young men leaving the Mexican countryside. The old and the very young are left behind, which creates a shortage of economically active people and a majority of women who have trouble finding male relationships. Remittances sent to Mexico are worth \$60 billion a year, though, and are the second most important source of income for the country. This money helps the economy as people now have money to spend on goods and services.

There are significant cultural and economic impacts on the USA. The US border states have been positively enriched by Mexican culture where language, music, and food have been adopted. Mexican and Mexican-inspired food has spread throughout the USA and can be found almost anywhere in the country. Americans, though, have mixed views about Mexican immigrants. Migrants take up a lot of the demand for cheap labour in the USA. Mexican immigrants often work for relatively low wages which is a benefit to the US economy. The low wages are used to prop up key industries such as agriculture, construction, and hospitality where a suitable labour pool does not exist within the USA. However, some Americans believe that paying migrant workers low wages also keeps their wages low and prevents American wages from increasing. Some Americans consider illegal immigration to be a burden on the economy due to the need for increased spending on social welfare, health, and education services. This opposition has been seen in the creation of Minutemen groups. These individuals seek to monitor illegal immigrants entering the USA by patrolling the US borders and confronting those who try to cross.



Figure 6.3: Mexican migrants cross the Rio Grande to enter the USA illegally



Source **B**: Cartoon about Mexico to US migration

TASK 2: Study Source **B**

In pairs, discuss the following questions:

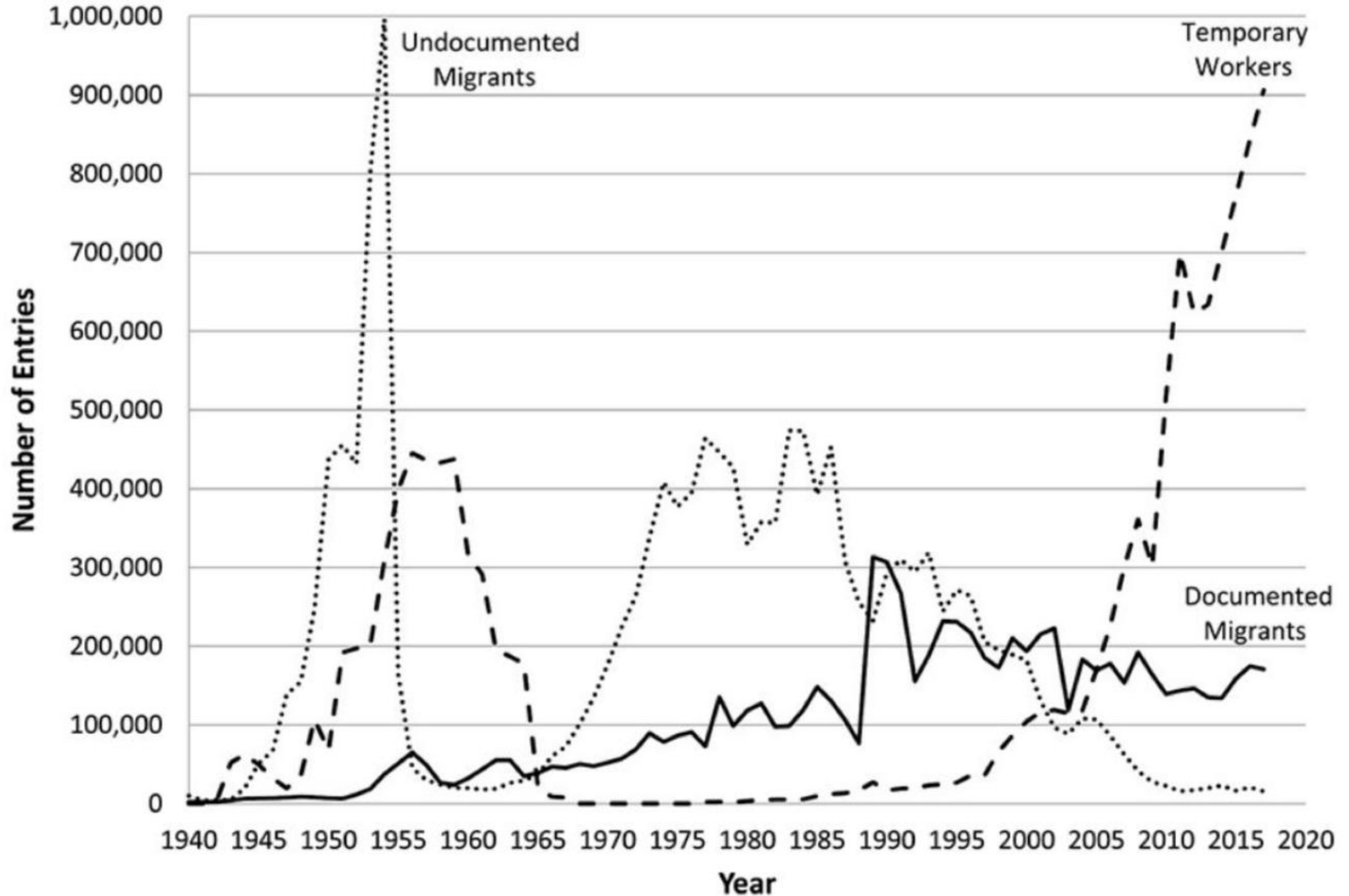
- a What is the message of the cartoon?
- b Give one social, economic, cultural, and political impact of Mexican migration to the USA.
- c Explain why the migration of Mexican immigrants to the USA is controversial.

REFLECTION

A lot of media stories portray migration to be a negative process. This is not always true. Do you generally think of only negative impacts? What could you do to learn more about positive impacts? Does hearing personal accounts help?

Managing migration

The management of migration from Mexico to the USA has been complex for a long time. The US government makes a distinction between 'Undocumented Migrants' (those living in the USA without a valid visa), 'Documented Migrants' (those legally admitted to the USA), and 'Temporary Workers' (those with a work visa allowing them to live in USA for a fixed period of time).



Source : Mexican migration to the US in three legal statuses

The Green Card is an important part of the United States' immigration system. It was first introduced in 1940. This policy allows individuals to live and work in the country on a long-term basis. All non-citizens had to register with the government and always carry a registration card.

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During the Second World War, many US workers worked in wartime industries and American farmers needed low-cost workers. In 1942, the USA and Mexico created the *bracero*, or labourer, programme, which encouraged Mexicans to come to the USA as contract workers. Many came as undocumented migrants. *Braceros* were generally paid very low wages, often working under conditions that most US citizens were unwilling to accept. The program was very popular with US farmers and did not end until 1964. More than five million Mexicans came to the USA as *braceros*, and hundreds of thousands stayed.

In 1965, the Immigration and Nationality Act was introduced. This allocated more Green Cards to occupations in industries that needed more workers, such as construction and hospitality, and for family members of US citizens. This led to a gradual rise in documented workers.

During the 1980s, there was a rise in undocumented migrants and in 1986, the Immigration Reform and Control Act was passed. This law ruled that any illegal migrants who had lived in the USA since 1928 could get Green Card status, and there were strict penalties for employers who hired illegal immigrants. However, this led to a problem with people trying to enter the USA with fake documents, as many Mexicans were desperate to leave Mexico and live in the USA. Border patrol increased as a result.

The 1990 Immigration Act increased the number of Green Cards issued to skilled workers and the 1996 Illegal Immigration Reform Act increased penalties for illegal entry, including detention and deportation. It also prevented illegal immigrants from using the legal system to gain a Green Card. However, this increased illegal immigrants' use of smugglers and reduced the incentives for illegal immigrants to return home.

In 2002, the US Congress passed the Homeland Security Act which included 850 miles of fencing along the Mexican/USA border and increased the size of Border Patrol. In 2005, the Mexican government also said it would take more responsibility for improving economic and social opportunities in Mexico to try to reduce the number of Mexicans wanting to leave. Between 2008 and 2016, the US government focused on enforcement and over 1.2 million (many Mexican) illegal immigrants were removed from the US in 8 years. The 2013 'Border Security, Economic opportunity and Immigration Modernisation Act' allowed more illegal immigrants to obtain registered immigration status by providing a work visa programme that provided temporary work visas for less skilled immigrants.

Between 2016 and 2020, the majority of Green Cards issued were for those Mexicans already living in the US, and the issue of Green Cards to people from abroad practically ended. Since 2020, illegal undocumented Mexican migration has continued to fall, and temporary work visas have continued to rise due to high demand in the USA for temporary agricultural workers and high skilled workers. More recently, there has been an increase in Mexicans leaving the US to return to families at a time when the US job market has suffered from recession and stricter border controls have been enforced.

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- a **Describe the pattern** of undocumented migrants from Mexico to the USA from 1940 to 2020.
- b Give reasons for the peak in undocumented migrants in the early 1950s.
- c Why has there been a gradual fall in undocumented migrants since 2000?



Figure 6.4: Section of Mexico to USA border wall

TASK 4

The building, monitoring, and maintenance of a border barrier is a very controversial strategy to control illegal immigration to the USA.

In pairs, carry out research to identify three advantages and three disadvantages of extending the border wall between Mexico and the USA.

IMPROVE THIS ANSWER

With reference to an example, describe, and explain the challenges and opportunities created by international migration to the destination country.

The world's largest bilateral migrant corridor is between the USA and Mexico. Mexico is the top origin country of the US immigrant population. In 2018, roughly 11.2 million immigrants (about one in ten Mexican citizens) living in the USA were from Mexico, accounting for 25% of all US immigrants ¹. Most people of Mexican origin living in the USA are authorised, but over the decades there have been hundreds of thousands who try to enter illegally ².

Legal and illegal migration brings social and economic challenges and opportunities to the US ³. Americans have mixed views about Mexican immigrants. Migrants take up a lot of the demand for cheap labour in the US. Mexican immigrants often work for relatively low wages which is a benefit to the US economy. The low wages are used to prop up key industries such as agriculture, construction and hospitality where a suitable labour pool does not exist within the US. However, some Americans believe that paying migrant workers low wages also keeps their wages low and prevents American wages from increasing. Some Americans consider illegal immigration to be a burden on the economy due to the need for increased spending on social welfare, health and education services. ⁴

This opposition has been seen in the creation of Minutemen groups. These individuals seek to monitor illegal immigrants entering the US by patrolling the US borders, and confronting those who try to cross. Illegal migration costs the US millions of dollars for border control such as security patrols and vertical fencing. ⁵

1 The answer gives an appropriate example with accurate and relevant information.

2 It is good that the answer makes a distinction between legal and illegal migration.

3 There is a clear focus on the destination country. To improve, the answer could also refer to cultural impacts of immigration.

4 This answer references social challenges, but not social opportunities for the destination country, which would bring more balance to the answer.

5 The answer needs to include a concluding sentence, for example, 'There are a range of social, economic, and cultural challenges and opportunities created by authorised and unauthorised migration from Mexico to the USA.'

Now, write an improved response to this answer using the guidance above.

SELF-EVALUATION CHECKLIST

After studying this topic, think about how confident you are with the different topics.
This will help you to find any gaps in your knowledge and learn more effectively.

I can:	Needs more work	Getting there	Ready to move on
describe and give reasons for the rapid increase in the world's population			
understand the main causes of growth and decline in a country's population			
understand and evaluate the demographic transition model			
identify and evaluate the implications of different types of population structure			
explain and give reasons for population migration			
understand some of the main impacts of migration.			



> Topic 7

Changing towns and cities

LEARNING INTENTIONS

By the end of this topic you will be able to:

- describe and give reasons for differences in urban growth around the world
- understand the main causes of rapid urban growth in LICs
- identify the opportunities of urban living
- explain the challenges and opportunities of rapid urban growth
- explain the impact of urban sprawl on the rural-urban fringe
- understand and evaluate sustainable management strategies of urban growth.

GETTING STARTED

Working in pairs, study the two images of Shanghai (Sources A and B) and then answer the following questions:

- 1 Describe the differences between the two images.
- 2 Why do you think Shanghai has seen such rapid economic growth in the last 30 years?
- 3 What do you think are some of the economic, social, and environmental consequences of such rapid urban development in cities such as Shanghai?



Source **A**: Shanghai 1990s



Source **B**: Shanghai 2023
